October 23, 2026

Rep. Himes and Brookings Experts Discuss Data Center Backlash, AI Security, and the 2026 Midterms

On Wednesday (October 21), the Brookings Institution's AI and Emerging Technology Initiative held an event titled “AI on the ballot: Data centers and the 2026 midterms.” At the event, House Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence Ranking Member Himes (D-CT) and several Brookings experts discussed how AI has become an issue in races across the country, from local concerns about data centers to the national security implications of building AI infrastructure overseas and the threat AI poses to election security.

Highlights.

Fireside Chat with Rep. Himes (D-CT). Rep. Himes (D-CT) warned that frontier AI models are showing what he called unbelievable hacking abilities, opening a new area of election security threats, and said AI makes it easier for foreign actors like Russia to create extremely realistic deepfakes. He said the backlash against data centers is solvable if local governments make sure these facilities do not draw heavily on public resources such as water, and said he believes the Ratepayer Protection Act, which stalled in the Senate, would have done little. Himes also called for more monitoring and transparency of frontier models and criticized how Anthropic framed its recent legislative proposal.

Building AI Infrastructure Abroad and Competition with China. Brookings’ Thomas Wright said inference compute largely needs to be built in the U.S. because of latency, and that energy-intensive training centers built outside the U.S. should be located with close allies, warning that facilities in the Middle East could be targeted. Kyle Chan noted that China generates more than twice as much electricity as the U.S. and is building up its energy to make up for its deficit in chips, cautioning that local backlash could slow U.S. compute if it slows the energy buildout.

Community Backlash and Local Leverage. Brookings’ Anthony Pipa and Mark Muro attributed growing local opposition to data centers to a lack of transparency, real risks to land, water, and air, and frustration with secretive deals and the way the technology is being imposed on communities. Pipa called for community benefits to move away from compensation and toward investment, including equity for communities. Muro said the backlash has elevated scrutiny of company behavior and created a moment for places to set their own development visions, pointing to free compute for universities and startups, housing aid, and support for small businesses as investments companies could provide.

Panelist Policy Recommendations. When asked to name one policy change that would improve the broader AI issue, Wright pointed to energy reform, and Chan called for streamlining power buildout and grid connection without raising electricity bills. Pipa proposed SWAT teams of lawyers or engineers to help local communities complete needed assessments, along with funding for community equity, while Muro called for states or the federal government to help make sure places have good development strategies and make good deals.

See below for more details from our select coverage of the event. As always, please reach out with any questions.

Fireside Chat with Rep. Jim Himes (D-CT).

- Rep. Jim Himes (D-CT), Ranking Member, House Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence
- Elham Tabassi, Director, Artificial Intelligence and Emerging Technology Initiative, Brookings Institution (*Moderator*)

AI and Election Security
Rep. Himes said AI is challenging election security through both election interference and election influence. On interference, he said it is very difficult to pull off, and he has never seen a meaningful operation, but warned that frontier models are showing unbelievable hacking abilities that create a whole new area of threats. On influence, Himes pointed to Russia's strategy of creating chaos and noted that AI makes it easier to generate extremely realistic deepfakes. However, he said he is glad American society has developed an immune system against them.

AI, Intelligence, and Privacy
Tabassi asked how access to the frontier models would help the IC. Himes said these models' cyber capabilities are extraordinary and moving much faster than anyone expected. The IC can now process and access data in ways that were previously unimaginable, citing improvements in visual imagery as an example. He did caveat that with a significant privacy issue, as AI enables the creation of extremely detailed profiles of individuals (he said the IC itself is probably not doing this, but other actors may be).

Grid Costs and Community Backlash
Tabassi asked who pays for the grid upgrades that data centers require. Himes pointed to the Ratepayer Protection Act, which passed the House but was blocked in the Senate, and said he believes the bill did not go far enough. He said he is not surprised by the backlash against data centers but believes it is immediately solvable if local governments make clear they will not commit large amounts of public resources, such as local water, to these facilities. Himes added that demand for compute still looks infinite, so the compute will get built, with companies offering communities more attractive deals. The federal government is possibly looking at military bases as sites.

Data Centers as Critical Infrastructure
Tabassi asked whether the big AI data centers would be classified as critical infrastructure. Himes said there's no doubt they will be, though it will be some time before policymakers work out exactly how they will protect them as the economy increasingly comes to depend on them. On the pros and cons, he noted that latency means inference compute will have to be built out in a very distributed way, which he thinks will be extremely difficult. He stated that building data centers in the Gulf raises security concerns, but those can be addressed. Himes also warned against the assumption that the U.S. will continue to lead on the frontier of Chinese models.

Jobs and the Political Debate
Himes said the political noise around AI focuses on problems rather than solutions, and that he is profoundly worried about the social impact if there are no jobs for people in their 20s and 30s a decade from now.

Priorities for the Next Congress
Tabassi asked Himes what he hopes the next Congress will do on AI. Himes said that members have taken the issue seriously and have been educating themselves, but he'd like to see something more to galvanize political action. He's called for much greater visibility into the frontier models, as well as strong monitoring and transparency. He also noted that Republicans in Congress will continue to defer to the President, who he said is taking an absolutist view on AI regulation. He did mention that

Congress could start with Anthropic's proposal, though he noted that he thought the way it was framed (only requiring a federal response if there were more than 50 deaths or serious injuries) was a terrible way to present policy. He added that private-sector people in AI are fundamentally different from the average person, and that's a massive issue.

Audience Questions
An audience member asked about putting data centers at sea or in space, the manipulation of public opinion on AI, and how Himes deals with AI questions at the town halls. Himes said people are very concerned about water and other resources, and that you have to start with the benefits we can offer, such as drug discovery and cancer treatment. He argued that the tech executives don't know how to talk to people emotionally. He pointed out that efficiency gains are already happening very rapidly, so you don't need to go to the moon to get them. As to whether you put them on the moon, under the sea, or in Greenland, that's the private sector's decision. His job is to make sure that it doesn't do any harm. He also referenced the allegations that China is spreading very inflammatory content about data centers, describing Russia as vandals who just want to create chaos and China as very direct and very calculated.

Spurring Congressional Action
Tabassi asked what would make Congress act with any real urgency. Himes replied that an incident involving the theft of classified information would do it. He said he hopes something bad (but not too bad) happens to get them moving. He also noted that some of the agencies are already using these models to test their own defensive capabilities.

Panel Discussion on Data Centers, Community Backlash, and Competition with China.

- Thomas Wright, Senior Fellow, Foreign Policy and Strobe Talbott Center for Security, Strategy, and Technology, Brookings Institution
- Kyle Chan, Fellow, Foreign Policy and John L. Thornton China Center, Brookings Institution
- Anthony F. Pipa, Senior Fellow, Global Economy and Development and Center for Sustainable Development, Brookings Institution
- Mark Muro, Senior Fellow, Brookings Metro
- Valerie Wirtschafter, Fellow, Foreign Policy and Artificial Intelligence and Emerging Technology Initiative, Brookings Institution (*Moderator*)

Building AI Infrastructure Abroad
Wirtschafter asked Wright about building AI infrastructure abroad. Wright replied that much of the inference side would have to stay domestic, since overseas inference centers would delay AI products. He added that the energy-intensive training centers could be located anywhere, though, and the question would be whether the U.S. has the energy, the power, and the permitting reforms to host them. He said the training centers would ideally be built in the U.S., warning that centers in the Middle East would be vulnerable to attack. He noted that the Biden administration was working through that issue at the end of its term. If they aren't built in the U.S., then they should be built with our closest allies.

The AI Race Framing
Wirtschafter asked whether running the buildout around Artificial General Intelligence (AGI) is in fact helping or damaging it by not in any way focused on actual, tangible benefits. Wright said the race shouldn't be justification for pushing a model that could be destabilizing, and argued that regulation should play a role in balancing innovation and safety. The race still matters, he said, pointing out it would have been a problem if China had built something like Mythos before us. He noted that chips are the only area in which the U.S. has an advantage, given China’s lead in energy.

Chips, Energy, and Local Resistance
Wirtschafter asked Chan whether local resistance would widen the gap between the U.S. lead in AI chips and China's lead in energy. Chan replied that while the U.S. complains about the grid and power availability, China complains that it doesn't have enough compute. He pointed out that China treats compute as a form of national infrastructure, that it generates more than twice the electricity of the U.S., has about three times the energy capacity, and is making massive investments in its grid. Chan explained that China is using that energy buildout to make up for its shortfall in chips, while the U.S. holds the edge in extremely energy efficient chips. He stated that the open question for the U.S. is whether it can build up enough inference capacity. He cautioned that community pushback could slow U.S. compute if it also slows the energy buildout.

Competing with China Abroad
Wirtschafter asked whether the U.S. needed to build abroad to stop China from taking over the data center space. Chan replied that, in the near term, the U.S. isn't competing with China overseas because China doesn't have the compute capacity to meet its own needs. In the longer term, he anticipates Chinese companies going global as chip manufacturing scales up. The real issue he sees is whether China can scale up its chip manufacturing to the point where it can compete with the U.S.

Community Opposition in West Virginia
Wirtschafter asked Pipa what was behind the resistance to the proposed data center in Tucker County, West Virginia. Pipa said the community has essentially turned itself into an arts and recreation town, and the state decides where these facilities go and takes 70% of the tax revenue. He identified three factors. The first was a total lack of transparency: the lease was completely unknown to the community, not even to local officials, and residents were only brought in at the very end. The second was the actual risks involved (land becoming a stranded asset, water issues, air emissions, runoff, etc.), which the community is forced to consider under time pressure. The third was a lack of trust in companies with such massive resources and local officials feeling completely outgunned, which in turn creates a vicious cycle.

Community Leverage and Equity
Wirtschafter asked whether moving these facilities to the United Arab Emirates or elsewhere would diminish communities' leverage. Pipa said communities aren't thinking about data centers going overseas. State leaders are concerned about losing the project to another state rather than another country, and that's the concern driving the race to the bottom. He said that while companies are looking for tax abatements, communities are looking for investment in schools, infrastructure, and amenities in return for the risk to their quality of life, and they can ask for that without necessarily driving the data centers away, as they still need those particular locations. Pipa also asked why communities shouldn't have equity and why community benefits should move away from compensation and toward investment.

Drivers of the National Backlash
Wirtschafter asked Muro how much of the backlash is specifically about the buildings themselves as opposed to AI in general. Muro said this summer's backlash is the culmination of complaints about energy use, pollution, noise, and the impact on the community at large. The data center 'mutiny' clearly shows how angry people are. He said the national backlash is not just about the big ugly buildings; it's about governance and transparency. Muro emphasized that Americans don't like secret deals, and they're very frustrated by the way this new technology is being thrust upon them.

What Communities Can Gain
Wirtschafter framed the data center backlash as a communications challenge and, citing Muro's February piece on community leverage, asked what data centers can offer. Muro stated that extreme demand, the need for speed, and the need for land give communities the basis to ask more of these

companies, and that the backlash has increased scrutiny and improved company behavior. He said firms are becoming more thoughtful, making this a moment for places to develop their own vision. He pointed to free compute for universities and startups, housing assistance, and small business support as investments companies could make.

Policy Recommendations
Wirtschafter asked each panelist for one policy change that would improve the overall AI issue. Wright pointed to energy reform. Chan said it was about streamlining the power buildout and grid connection so that data centers can get the power they need without the electricity bills going up. Pipa suggested SWAT teams of lawyers and/or engineers to help local communities complete the assessments they need, along with funding for community equity. Muro called for states and/or the federal government to step in and help communities develop strong strategies and make good deals.

Accountability for Community Benefit Agreements
During Q&A, one attendee asked who should hold the hyperscalers to account for their Community Benefit Agreements (CBA) and who would enforce them if they didn't deliver on their promises. Muro said the states are responsible, since they sit between localities and the federal government, and have significant control over environmental and electricity levers. He noted that the states are increasingly taking on this role. Pipa said the action is now clearly going to the states, as the federal government is doing absolutely nothing and that without a common standard there is a real need for some form of national guidance.

Energy Needs in the U.S. and China
An attendee asked Chan how each country's capacity relates to its own needs. Chan said that across the U.S., the issue is broadly one of capacity (i.e., more energy is required), whereas in China the issue is more regional. The western provinces (e.g. Inner Mongolia) have a lot of renewable energy and are using compute to absorb that.

Rhetoric and AI Philanthropy
Another person asked how AI philanthropy might affect tech policy and whether labeling tech CEOs as inhuman would, in fact, generate more anger about data centers. Wirtschafter said the anger is more about the lack of communication from tech CEOs (which she said breeds mistrust) and companies taking over land. However, she agreed people should be careful with the language. Pipa said the 'how' of AI philanthropy is absolutely critical, and it should be focused on communities, many of which could quite happily take on that capital if the companies just communicated with them.